and I thought it was important for us to try to get the ball outside the thirty-yard circle to make it wet. That would mean the ball would stop swinging. Unfortunately for us, we lost Sehwag for a duck in the first over of the chase and it was down to Gambhir and me to build a platform. I hit a couple of crisp boundaries and was timing the ball well, but just when I thought the ball had stopped swinging, I was tempted to play a drive outside the off stump. That ball from Malinga swung and I edged it to the wicketkeeper and was out for 18. It was disappointing, and I won't forget the walk back to the dressing room.

We were in a potentially dangerous situation when Virat Kohli arrived at the crease to join Gambhir. Virat had started the World Cup with a hundred against Bangladesh and now he finished off with a key innings in the final. The importance of his contribution is not always acknowledged, but his 35 was part of a key partnership, as both Gautam and Virat managed to score at a brisk pace and so the asking rate was never out of reach. Once Virat was out, Dhoni promoted himself up the order to negotiate the Sri Lankan off-spinners, Muralitharan, Randiv and Dilshan. It was the Gambhir–Dhoni partnership of 109 that won us the World Cup. Both played exceptionally well under intense pressure.

I have to confess that I did not actually see what millions of Indians watched with ecstasy and delight that night. I did not see my ultimate dream being fulfilled, the moment I had waited to savour since making my international debut in November 1989. The reason was that when Mahendra Singh Dhoni hit the winning six at the Wankhede Stadium, I was with Virender Sehwag in the dressing room praying. I wasn't asking God to help us win. All I wanted was that God should do what was best for us, for Indian cricket and for the Indian cricket team. I had turned superstitious on the night and made Viru sit near me in one position. Neither of us ventured out till Dhoni's shot had crossed the boundary. A little earlier, when it seemed that an Indian win was on the cards, Viru had wanted to go out of the dressing room to celebrate. I advised him not to till the match was finally over. I said to him that he could watch the moment a hundred times on television if he wanted to, but for the time being he should just sit where he was and pray. It was only after Dhoni's shot had finally crossed the boundary that I went out.

Many people have asked me what I felt at that particular moment. Frankly, at first it was difficult to take in that we had won the World Cup. It was almost as if there was still a match left in the tournament. But